area (HAA), with our highest post being at Point 5299 (5299 m above mean sea level, or about 16,400 ft). Being an HAA, it was only a two-year tenure, so the unit was already slated to be moving out to Meerut, with the advance party under Lt Col AVS Ghuman, the 2iC, already in station. In anticipation of that move, we packed up from Pune and shifted to Meerut, staying in a two-room set in the Officers' Mess. The girls were admitted to the Sophia Girls School and Veena also got a job in the same school. It was a big relief for all of them to be going to the same school, as in Pune, all three had been going to different institutions in different parts of the town. Having settled them in, I proceeded to Kaksar, up to Jammu by train and then by road convoy to Kaksar with an overnight halt at the Srinagar transit camp. This was thus my third tenure in J & K. In those pre-Kargil War (1999) days, the entire area from Dras to Kargil was looked after solely by 121(I) Inf Bde, with its HQ at Kargil, reporting directly to the 15 Corps at Srinagar.[4] Our Battalion, 7 SIKH LI, was at Kaksar with the Companies deployed on the dominating heights on both sides of the Shingo River, in a sensitive area called Intrusion Dalunang.

Intrusion Dalunang has an interesting history. There used to be an old trade route going along the Eastern bank of the Shingo River from Kaksar, via Dalunang and Kunar to Gultari. When the LC was demarcated post the 1971 war, Dalunang came on our side and Kunar on the Pakistani side. Prior to the war, Dalunang had been evacuated and the route from Kaksar to Dalunang was mined. Post the ceasefire, no one had actually gone to the village; neither the villagers nor the Army. A few years later, around 1975, the villagers wanted to go back to their village and started clamouring for compensation for the harvest of their apricot trees. The DC, a conscientious person, wanted to see the village and these apricot trees for himself,

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